WHICH OF OUR AGENCIES' RESULTS ACTUALLY HAPPENED?

Three agencies claimed 4,200 results. In this example, 1,380 held up. We line up each agency's claims against your own numbers, whether that's sales, tickets, sign-ups or streams, and show which ones hold up.

4,200 → 1,380 Example: results three agencies claimed between them, and how many held up

Your agencies' reports, your own numbers (sales, tickets, sign-ups or viewing), and the ad accounts the reports cover.

Why check at all

This is an example walk-through. Every number on this page is an example, made up to show the method. Your answer would use your agencies' claims and your own numbers.

Picture a brand working with three agencies: one for social, one for search, one for creators. Each sends a monthly report. Each report looks reasonable on its own. Added together, the example claims come to 4,200 results for the quarter, and the brand's own numbers don't show anything like that many.

It matters because budget follows those reports. If two agencies are both claiming the same sale, or claiming results that came from your own emails, you are paying twice for work that happened once. The agency check sorts it out before the next renewal.

The answer, slide by slide

THE HEADLINE

THEY SAID 4,200. WE FOUND 1,380.

Example numbers. Each claim is checked against your own numbers. 2,820 didn't hold up.

HOW WE MATCH

EVERY CLAIM, COUNTED ONCE.

Example. Each sale, ticket or sign-up an agency claims is checked against your own numbers by date, title or product, and channel. Each one can be matched once. If two agencies claim it, it goes to neither until a test says otherwise.

WHERE THE REST WENT

2,820 CLAIMS DIDN'T HOLD UP.

Example. 1,610 were counted by two agencies at once. 740 came from your own emails. 470 came from people already searching your name.

AGENCY BY AGENCY

- **Social:** Claimed 2,100. Matched 820.
- **Search:** Claimed 1,300. Matched 310, most of it brand search.
- **Creators:** Claimed 800. Matched 250, after coupon-site codes.

WHAT WE'D TEST

PAUSE BRAND SEARCH IN HALF YOUR REGIONS FOR THREE WEEKS.

Example. If sales hold in the paused regions, that budget can go somewhere that earns it. If they drop, you know the channel works, and you know by how much.

WHAT TO DO

- **Ask:** Take the list of claims that didn't hold up to your next agency review.
- **Test:** For anything you'd move budget on, run a regions-on, regions-off test.
- **Renew:** Keep the agencies whose claims hold up. You'll know which ones.

How we answered it

1. **Collect every claim, line by line.** We take each agency's report and break it into individual claims: a date, a channel, a product or title, and a count. Example: the three agencies together claim 4,200 results for the quarter. Anything an agency counts goes on the list, whether it's sales, tickets, sign-ups, streams or viewing.
2. **Pull your own numbers for the same period.** We pull your own record of results for the same dates: sales, tickets, sign-ups, streams or viewing, whichever your business counts. We also look at the ad accounts each report covers, so we know what ran and when. [Confirm: read-only access to ad accounts and first-party data.]
3. **Match each claim by date, product or title, and channel.** Each claim is matched to a result in your own numbers. The result has to fall inside the agency's stated window, be for the product or title the agency promoted, and come through a channel the agency ran. Claims that can't be matched don't hold up.
4. **Count each result once.** A result can be matched to one claim only. If two agencies claim the same result, it goes to neither until a test settles it. That one rule is what keeps the total from adding up to more than you sold.
5. **Sort the claims that fall out.** Every claim that didn't hold up gets a reason: counted by two agencies at once, came from your own email, or came from people already searching your name. Example: 2,820 claims fall out, and each one has a reason attached.
6. **Test what you would move budget on.** Matching shows what holds up. It doesn't show cause. For any channel you might cut or grow, we design a regions-on, regions-off test, called a holdout: run it in some regions, pause it in others, and compare your own numbers.

Everything we found

4,200 → 1,380

Example: they claimed 4,200. 1,380 held up.

Example numbers. Across the three agencies, 4,200 results were claimed for the quarter. When each claim was matched against the brand's own numbers by date, product and channel, and each result was counted once, 1,380 held up. The other 2,820 didn't. That doesn't mean the agencies did no work. It means the reports were counting in ways that can't all be true at once.

1,610

Example: 1,610 were counted by two agencies at once

Example numbers. The biggest single reason claims fell out was overlap. A buyer saw a creator's video, clicked a social ad a week later and bought, and both agencies counted the sale. Each platform gives itself credit whenever its ad was on the path. Under the count-once rule, those 1,610 go to neither agency until a test shows which one moved them.

740

Example: 740 came from your own emails

Example numbers. 740 claimed results came through the brand's own email, where the buyer happened to have seen an ad earlier. Your email list is yours. A result that arrives from a click in your own newsletter isn't an agency's to claim, even if their ad was in the buyer's history.

470

Example: 470 came from people already searching your name

Example numbers. 470 results came from people who typed the brand's name into a search engine and clicked a paid ad on the way to a page they were already looking for. Brand search ads catch people who already decided. Some of that spend protects your name from competitors; some of it pays for visits you would have had anyway. Only a test tells you which.

2,100 → 820

Example: social claimed 2,100 and matched 820

Example numbers. The social agency's report claimed the most of the three. 820 of its claims matched a result in the brand's own numbers and weren't claimed by anyone else. That is its contribution, and the number to judge it on at renewal.

1,300 → 310

Example: search claimed 1,300 and matched 310, most of it brand search

Example numbers. The search agency's claims fell the furthest, because a large share came from people already searching the brand's name. Of the 310 that held up, most were still brand search. Before renewing, the question for this agency is how much non-brand search it is running, and what that does.

800 → 250

Example: creators claimed 800 and matched 250, after coupon-site codes

Example numbers. Creator agencies often count every use of a creator's discount code. Those codes leak onto coupon sites, where shoppers who were already buying go looking for a discount. After removing code uses that came through coupon sites, 250 of the creator agency's 800 claims matched.

3 weeks

Example: the test to run next is pausing brand search in half your regions

Example. Pause brand search in half your regions for three weeks and leave it on in the rest. If sales hold in the paused regions, that budget can move somewhere that earns it. If they drop, you know the channel works, and by how much. Either answer is worth more than another quarter of reports.

What we told them to do

- **Count once:** Every result is counted once, starting from your own numbers. If two agencies claim it, it goes to neither until a test decides.
- **Match on three things:** Date, product or title, and channel. A claim that misses any of the three doesn't hold up.
- **Give every dropped claim a reason:** Counted twice, came from your own email, or came from people already searching your name. A reason turns an argument into a list.
- **Test before you move budget:** Matching shows what holds up. A regions-on, regions-off test shows what caused it. Run one before any big cut or increase.
- **Take the list to the review:** Bring the claims that didn't hold up to your next agency review, line by line. Keep the agencies whose claims hold up.

What any brand can take from this

- **Start from your own numbers.** Agency reports start from the platform and count outward, so they overlap. Start from the results you can see in your own records and work back. The total can never add up to more than you got.
- **Ask every agency the same two questions.** How do you count a result, a click or a view? And how many days after the ad do you still count it? Different answers explain most of the overlap before you look at a single line.
- **Treat brand search and discount codes with care.** Both catch people who were already on their way. Both can look like the best channels in a report. Check them first, and test them before you scale them.
- **A fair count helps good agencies.** An agency doing strong work keeps its results under a count-once rule, and gets a clean number to defend at renewal. The check protects the budget and the good partners at once.

What this doesn't prove

- Every number on this page is an example. Your report uses your agencies' claims and your own numbers, and the split will look different.
- Matching removes double counting and claims that weren't an agency's to make. It doesn't prove that a matched result was caused by the ad. That takes a regions-on, regions-off test.

- The check is only as detailed as the agency reports. If a report gives totals with no dates or channels, fewer claims can be matched, and the report says so.
- A claim that didn't hold up isn't an accusation. Most overlap comes from how each platform counts, and the agency may not see the other agencies' numbers.

Example numbers. Your report uses your agencies' claims and your own numbers.

Your question is next. Bring Arcus one question. We answer it with your own numbers and what people say, and walk you through it in 30 minutes. Free, no card. usearcus.ai/free-report